

Psychology and Counseling as Applied Sciences

Why do people think, feel, and act the way they do? Why do some individuals struggle with anxiety or depression while others seem resilient? How can one person help another through listening, empathy, and evidence-based techniques? These questions lie at the heart of psychology and counseling. Psychology seeks to understand the human mind and behavior through systematic research. Counseling applies psychological knowledge to help individuals cope with life's challenges, heal from emotional wounds, and grow toward greater well-being. Together, they form a continuum from understanding to action – from theory to practice.

This reading material examines the concepts, major theories, methods, and career pathways of psychology, including Filipino indigenous psychological concepts. It also analyzes the key theories, methods, and career pathways of counseling as an applied social science, including the influence of Filipino cultural values on counseling practices.

Part 1: Defining Psychology and Its Relevance

What Is Psychology?

Psychology is the scientific study of the human mind, behavior, and mental processes. It seeks to understand how people perceive, think, feel, learn, remember, and interact with others. Unlike casual observation or common sense, psychology uses systematic methods – experiments, surveys, observations, and neuroimaging – to test hypotheses and build evidence-based knowledge.

The Goals of Psychology

Goal	Explanation
Describe	To observe and document behavior accurately
Explain	To understand why behavior occurs (identify causes)
Predict	To anticipate when and under what conditions behavior will occur
Control or influence	To apply knowledge to improve human well-being (therapy, education, policy)

Why Psychology Matters

Area	Contribution of Psychology
Health	Understanding and treating mental disorders (depression, anxiety, schizophrenia)
Education	Improving learning methods, addressing learning disabilities, motivating students
Work	Enhancing productivity, job satisfaction, leadership, and teamwork
Law	Assessing criminal competency, understanding eyewitness testimony, profiling
Daily life	Managing stress, improving relationships, making better decisions

Part 2: Major Psychological Theories

Psychology is not a single unified field. It contains multiple major theories, each offering a different perspective on human behavior and mental processes.

Major Schools of Thought in Psychology

School	Key Thinkers	Core Idea
Psychoanalysis	Sigmund Freud	Unconscious drives, childhood experiences, and defense mechanisms shape personality and behavior. Symptoms have hidden psychological meanings.
Behaviorism	John Watson, B.F. Skinner	Psychology should study only observable behavior. Behavior is shaped by reinforcement (rewards) and punishment.
Humanistic Psychology	Carl Rogers, Abraham Maslow	Emphasizes free will, self-actualization, and the inherent goodness of human nature. People strive to reach their full potential.
Cognitive Psychology	Jean Piaget, Ulric Neisser	Focuses on mental processes: memory, thinking, problem-solving, decision-making, and language.
Biological Psychology	Various	Behavior and mental processes are explained by brain structures, neurotransmitters, genetics, and evolution.
Sociocultural Psychology	Lev Vygotsky	Behavior is shaped by cultural context, social norms, and interactions with others.

Key Concepts from Major Theories

Theory	Key Concept	Explanation
Psychoanalysis	Unconscious mind	Thoughts, memories, and desires outside conscious awareness that influence behavior
Psychoanalysis	Defense mechanisms	Unconscious strategies (repression, projection, denial) that protect the ego from anxiety
Behaviorism	Classical conditioning	Learning through association (Pavlov's dogs)
Behaviorism	Operant conditioning	Learning through consequences (reinforcement and punishment)
Humanistic	Self-actualization	The innate drive to reach one's full potential
Humanistic	Unconditional positive regard	Acceptance and support of a person regardless of what they say or do
Cognitive	Cognitive distortions	Irrational thought patterns that contribute to emotional distress (e.g., catastrophizing, black-and-white thinking)

Part 3: Filipino Indigenous Psychological Concepts

Sikolohiyang Pilipino (Filipino Psychology) is a movement that began in the 1970s led by Virgilio Enriquez. It rejects the uncritical importation of Western psychological theories and methods. Instead, it develops concepts, theories, and research methods rooted in Filipino language, culture, and lived experience.

Core Concepts of Sikolohiyang Pilipino

Concept	Meaning	Application
Kapwa	Shared identity; the recognition of the self in others; "togetherness"	The core value of Filipino psychology. Treating others as kapwa means seeing them as equal, not as "ibang tao" (outsider).
Pakikipagkapwa	The act of treating others with dignity and respect	Essential for building trust in counseling and research relationships
Pakikiramdam	Shared inner perception; sensitivity to unspoken cues	A heightened emotional awareness that guides appropriate social behavior
Utang na loob	Debt of gratitude; a sense of obligation to repay kindness	Shapes family and community relationships; must be understood in counseling contexts
Hiya	Shame or embarrassment	Not simply negative; it can be a moral emotion that guides proper behavior
Pakikisama	Conformity to group norms; getting along with others	Important in group settings and community interventions
Lakas ng loob	Courage or guts	Inner strength to face challenges; a positive trait to cultivate in therapy
Bahala na	Fatalistic acceptance; leaving things to God or fate	Often misunderstood as passivity; can also represent risk-taking and courage in uncertainty

Importance of Indigenous Concepts in Psychology

Reason	Explanation
Cultural relevance	Western theories may not apply to Filipino experience
Ethical practice	Respects local values and avoids imposing foreign frameworks
Accurate assessment	Understanding hiya prevents misinterpreting shame as pathology
Effective intervention	Counseling that respects kapwa and pakikiramdam builds trust

Part 4: Methods of Inquiry in Psychology

Psychologists use multiple methods to study behavior and mental processes. Each method has strengths and limitations.

Major Research Methods

Method	Description	Strength	Limitation
Experimental method	Manipulating an independent variable to measure its effect on a dependent variable	Can establish cause and effect	Often artificial (lab settings); ethical limits
Correlational method	Measuring the relationship between two variables without manipulation	Can study variables that cannot be experimentally manipulated	Cannot prove causation

Survey method	Collecting self-reported data from large samples using questionnaires	Efficient; can reach many participants	Self-report bias; cannot establish causation
Case study	In-depth study of a single individual or small group	Rich detail; useful for rare conditions	Cannot generalize to larger population
Naturalistic observation	Observing behavior in natural settings without interference	High realism	Cannot control variables; observer bias
Longitudinal study	Following the same participants over a long period	Shows change over time	Time-consuming; expensive; participant dropout

Ethical Principles in Psychological Research

Principle	Explanation
Informed consent	Participants must be fully informed about the research and agree to participate voluntarily
Confidentiality	Personal information must be protected and kept private
Debriefing	After participation, researchers explain the true purpose and address any concerns
Right to withdraw	Participants may leave the study at any time without penalty
No harm	Participants must not be physically or psychologically harmed

Part 5: Career Pathways in Psychology

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Clinical Psychologist	Private practice, hospitals, mental health clinics	Diagnose and treat mental disorders; provide therapy; conduct psychological assessments
Counseling Psychologist	Schools, universities, community centers	Help individuals cope with life challenges (relationship, career, academic)
School Psychologist	Schools, school districts	Assess learning disabilities; support student emotional well-being
Industrial-Organizational Psychologist	Corporations, consulting firms	Improve employee selection, training, motivation, and workplace culture
Forensic Psychologist	Courts, prisons, law enforcement	Evaluate competency; assess risk; provide expert testimony
Developmental Psychologist	Research institutes, early childhood centers	Study changes across the lifespan (childhood, aging)
Social Psychologist	Universities, research firms	Study group behavior, prejudice, conformity, persuasion
Neuropsychologist	Hospitals, clinics, research labs	Assess brain-behavior relationships (brain injuries, dementia)

Part 6: Defining Counseling as an Applied Social Science

What Is Counseling?

Counseling is an applied social science that uses structured, empathic conversation to help individuals address personal challenges, improve mental health, and achieve greater well-being. Unlike clinical psychology which often focuses on severe mental disorders, counseling typically addresses everyday life challenges: relationship difficulties, career decisions, grief, stress, and personal growth. However, the boundaries between counseling and clinical psychology overlap significantly in practice.

Counseling as an Applied Social Science

Feature	Explanation
Applies theory	Uses psychological theories (humanistic, cognitive, behavioral) to guide practice
Evidence-based	Uses methods and techniques supported by research
Contextual	Recognizes that individuals are shaped by family, culture, society, and environment
Collaborative	Counselor and client work together as partners, not expert and patient
Strengths-based	Focuses on client's capacities and resources, not just problems

Goals of Counseling

Goal	Explanation
Alleviate distress	Reduce symptoms of anxiety, depression, grief, or trauma
Develop coping skills	Teach strategies to manage stress, emotions, and difficult situations
Improve relationships	Enhance communication, boundary-setting, and conflict resolution
Facilitate decision-making	Clarify values and options for career, relationships, or life changes
Promote growth	Support self-awareness, self-acceptance, and movement toward potential

Part 7: Major Counseling Theories

Counseling draws from several major theoretical frameworks. Each offers a different understanding of human problems and how to address them.

Major Counseling Theories

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea	Counseling Approach
Person-Centered Therapy	Carl Rogers	People have inherent capacity for growth. Problems arise when conditions of worth block self-actualization.	Provide unconditional positive regard, empathy, and genuineness. Client leads the way.

Theory	Key Thinkers	Core Idea	Counseling Approach
Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CBT)	Aaron Beck, Albert Ellis	Psychological distress results from distorted thinking patterns and maladaptive behaviors.	Identify and challenge cognitive distortions; change behaviors through exposure and practice.
Psychodynamic Therapy	Sigmund Freud, later theorists	Unconscious conflicts from childhood shape adult behavior and relationships.	Explore past experiences, defense mechanisms, and transference (projecting feelings onto therapist).
Solution-Focused Brief Therapy	Steve de Shazer, Insoo Kim Berg	Focus on solutions, not problems. Clients already have resources to improve.	Ask exception questions ("When is the problem not happening?"); set small, achievable goals.
Feminist Therapy	Various	Psychological distress is shaped by gender inequality and social oppression.	Empower clients; challenge oppressive social norms; attend to power dynamics in therapy.

Key Counseling Techniques

Technique	Used In	Description
Active listening	All therapies	Fully attending to client's verbal and nonverbal messages; reflecting, paraphrasing, summarizing

Reflection of feeling	Person-centered	Naming the emotion the client appears to be experiencing ("It sounds like you feel angry...")
Cognitive restructuring	CBT	Identifying and challenging irrational or distorted thoughts
Behavioral activation	CBT	Encouraging engagement in positive activities to improve mood
Empty chair technique	Gestalt	Client speaks to an empty chair as if a significant person were sitting there
Scaling questions	Solution-focused	Asking client to rate progress on a scale of 1 to 10

Part 8: Filipino Indigenous Concepts in Counseling

Filipino cultural values profoundly shape how counseling is practiced in the Philippine context. A culturally competent counselor understands and respects these values.

Influence of Filipino Cultural Values on Counseling Practices

Cultural Value	Influence on Counseling	Practical Application
Kapwa (shared identity)	Counseling is a collaborative, relational process, not a detached expert-patient relationship	Counselor uses inclusive language ("tayo," "ating"); builds trust before intervening
Pakikiramdam (sensitivity to unspoken cues)	Clients may not directly state distress; counselor must read indirect communication	Observe nonverbal behavior, hesitation, and what is left unsaid

Cultural Value	Influence on Counseling	Practical Application
Hiya (shame)	Clients may feel shame about seeking help or admitting problems	Normalize help-seeking; ensure privacy; use indirect approaches initially
Utang na loob (debt of gratitude)	Client may feel obligated to please the counselor or show progress	Clarify that there is no debt; emphasize mutual respect
Pakikisama (conformity to group norms)	Family and community involvement is expected	Include family members when appropriate; respect group harmony
Lakas ng loob (courage)	Reframe help-seeking as courage, not weakness	Affirm client's strength in seeking counseling
Bahala na (fatalistic acceptance)	May affect client's sense of agency and responsibility for change	Gently explore what client can control while respecting spiritual beliefs

Culturally Adapted Counseling Approaches

Approach	Description
Pagmamano	Using the traditional gesture of respect (raising elder's hand to forehead) to establish rapport
Pagsasalarawan (storytelling)	Using indirect, narrative approaches rather than direct questioning
Pakikipagkuwentuhan	Framing counseling as shared storytelling rather than clinical interview

Pagpapahalaga sa
pamilya

Explicitly acknowledging and including family relationships in the
counseling process

Part 9: Key Counseling Methods and Techniques

The Counseling Process

Stage	What Happens
1. Establishing rapport	Building trust; creating a safe, confidential environment
2. Assessment	Gathering information about the client's concerns, history, and strengths
3. Goal setting	Collaboratively defining what the client wants to achieve
4. Intervention	Applying therapeutic techniques appropriate to the client's needs
5. Termination	Ending the counseling relationship; reviewing progress; planning for the future

Core Counseling Skills

Skill	Description
Attending	Physical and psychological presence; eye contact, open posture, facing the client
Listening	Hearing not only words but also emotions, values, and unspoken meanings

Skill	Description
Empathy	Understanding the client's experience from their perspective without judgment
Reflection	Paraphrasing what the client said to show understanding and encourage elaboration
Questioning	Using open-ended questions (What? How? Tell me about...) not closed-ended (Yes/No)
Summarizing	Pulling together key themes from a session
Confrontation (gentle)	Pointing out discrepancies between what the client says and does, or between words and nonverbal behavior

Part 10: Career Pathways in Counseling

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
School Counselor	Elementary, secondary schools	Academic guidance; career counseling; social-emotional support for students
Guidance Counselor (Philippines)	Public and private schools	RA 9258 regulates the profession; requires licensure examination
Rehabilitation Counselor	Rehabilitation centers, hospitals	Helping individuals with disabilities achieve personal and career goals
Mental Health Counselor	Community mental health centers, clinics	Treating anxiety, depression, trauma, grief

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Career Counselor	Universities, workforce development agencies	Assisting with career exploration, job search, and career transitions
Private Practice Counselor	Self-employed	Providing counseling services to individuals, couples, or families for a fee
Crisis Counselor	Hotlines, disaster response teams	Providing immediate emotional support during emergencies
Guidance and Counseling Specialist	Department of Education (DepEd), CHED	Policy development; training of guidance counselors; program evaluation

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Psychology	The scientific study of the human mind, behavior, and mental processes
Counseling	An applied social science using structured conversation to help individuals address personal challenges
Sikolohiyang Pilipino	Filipino indigenous psychology; concepts and methods rooted in Filipino language and culture
Kapwa	Shared identity; treating others as equal, not as outsider
Pakikiramdam	Sensitivity to unspoken cues; shared inner perception
Person-Centered Therapy	Rogers' approach emphasizing unconditional positive regard, empathy, and genuineness
Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CBT)	Therapy focusing on changing distorted thoughts and maladaptive behaviors
Active listening	Fully attending to and reflecting client's verbal and nonverbal messages
Licensure Examination for Guidance Counselors	Required examination to practice as a registered guidance counselor in the Philippines (RA 9258)

Review Questions

1. Define psychology in your own words. What are the four goals of psychology?
2. Identify three major schools of thought in psychology. For each, state one key thinker and one core idea.
3. What is Sikolohiyang Pilipino? Who led its development? Explain the concept of kapwa and why it is central to Filipino psychology.
4. Describe two methods of inquiry used in psychological research. For each method, state one strength and one limitation.
5. List three career pathways in psychology. For each, state the typical work setting and one task performed.
6. Define counseling as an applied social science. How does counseling differ from casual conversation or advice-giving?
7. Identify three major counseling theories. For each, state the core idea and one technique associated with that theory.
8. Explain how Filipino cultural values influence counseling practices. Choose two values (e.g., hiya, pakikiramdam, utang na loob) and describe how a counselor should respond to each.
9. What are the five stages of the counseling process? Briefly describe what happens in each stage.
10. Application question: A Filipino university student seeks counseling for anxiety about upcoming board examinations. The student mentions hiya about failing and says "Bahala na." Using Filipino indigenous concepts and appropriate counseling techniques, describe how a culturally competent counselor might respond.